

NEW MEXICO WILDFIRE RESOURCE GUIDE



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Available Federal Assistance

United States Department of Agriculture (USDA)

The USDA has several disaster assistance programs for crop and livestock losses; to rehabilitate farmland, watersheds, and forests; and to provide support for rural businesses and homes.

Natural Resources Conservation Service (NRCS) Programs

For assistance with any NRCS programs, please contact:

J. Xavier Montoya, State Conservationist
(505) 761-4402
Xavier.Montoya@usda.gov

Adrian D. Tafoya, South Area Conservationist
(575) 522-8775, 115
adrian.tafoya@usda.gov

The Emergency Watershed Protection Program offers technical and financial assistance to help local communities relieve imminent threats to life and property caused by floods, fires, windstorms, and other natural disasters that impair a watershed. For more information, visit <https://www.nrcs.usda.gov/wps/portal/nrcs/main/national/programs/landscape/ewpp/> or contact the New Mexico Watershed Protection Program Director, Kenneth Branch, at (505) 761-4454 or Kenneth.Branch@usda.gov.

Environmental Quality Incentives Program (EQIP) Farmers, ranchers, and non-industrial private forestland owners can apply for resource assistance through the Environmental Quality Incentives Program. Eligible land includes cropland, rangeland, and non-industrial private forestland. Recovery assistance includes but is not limited to: immediate soil erosion protection, minimizing noxious and invasive plant proliferation, protecting water quality, restoring livestock infrastructure necessary for grazing management, emergency animal mortality management. For more information, visit https://www.nrcs.usda.gov/Internet/FSE_MEDIA/nrcseprd1429025.pdf or contact your local NRCS Office.

Farm Service Agency (FSA) Programs

For assistance with any FSA programs, please contact:

NEW MEXICO STATE FARM SERVICE AGENCY
100 SUN AVENUE NE
ALBUQUERQUE, NM 87109
(800) 410-2067
(505) 761-4900
(877) 450-0860 Fax
Mailing Address:
100 SUN AVENUE NE, SUITE 200
ALBUQUERQUE, NM 87109

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The FSA Emergency Forest Restoration Program provides a range of benefits to private landowners, including repairing fencing, planting trees, and road repair to restore forest health. For more information, please visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/programs-and-services/disaster-assistance-program/emergency-forest-restoration/index>.

The Emergency Conservation Program provides funding assistance to farmers and ranchers to repair damaged farmland and to install methods of water conservation. For more information, visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/programs-and-services/conservation-programs/emergency-conservation/index>.

The Livestock Forage Disaster Program (LFP) provides benefits for grazing losses due to wildfire. LFP benefits may also be available for loss of grazing acres due to wildfires on federally managed lands on which a producer is prohibited, by a federal agency, from grazing normally permitted livestock. For more information, visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/programs-and-services/disaster-assistance-program/livestock-forage/index>.

The Livestock Indemnity Program (LIP) provides benefits to livestock producers for livestock deaths in excess of normal mortality caused by adverse weather or by attacks by animals reintroduced into the wild by the federal government. For more information, visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/programs-and-services/disaster-assistance-program/livestock-indemnity/index>.

The Emergency Assistance for Livestock, Honeybees, and Farm-Raised Fish provides emergency assistance to eligible producers of livestock, honeybees and farm-raised fish for losses due to disease (including cattle tick fever), adverse weather, or other conditions, such as blizzards and wildfires, not covered by LFP and LIP. For more information, visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/Assets/USDA-FSA-Public/usdafiles/FactSheets/elap-livestock-fact-sheet.pdf>.

The Emergency Loan Program provides loans to help producers recover from production and physical losses due to drought, flooding, other natural disasters, or quarantine by animal quarantine laws or imposed by the Secretary under the Plant Protection Act. For more information, visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/programs-and-services/farm-loan-programs/emergency-farm-loans/index>.

The Disaster Set-Aside Program provides producers who have existing direct loans with FSA who are unable to make the scheduled payments to move up to one full year's payment to the end of the loan. Assistance is available in counties, or contiguous counties, who have been designated as emergencies by the President, Secretary or FSA Administrator. For more information, visit <https://www.fsa.usda.gov/Assets/USDA-FSA-Public/usdafiles/FactSheets/2019/disaster-set-aside-program-factsheet-19.pdf>.

Noninsured Disaster Assistance Program (NAP) pays covered producers of covered noninsurable crops when low yields, loss of inventory, or prevented planting occur due to natural disasters (includes native grass for grazing). Eligible producers must have purchased NAP coverage for the current crop year. For more information, visit https://www.fsa.usda.gov/Assets/USDA-FSA-Public/usdafiles/FactSheets/noninsured_crop_disaster_assistance_program-nap-fact_sheet.pdf.

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Tree Assistance Program (TAP) provides financial assistance to qualifying orchardists and nursery tree growers to replant or rehabilitate eligible trees, bushes, and vines damaged by natural disasters. Learn more about TAP. For more information, visit

https://www.fsa.usda.gov/Assets/USDA-FSA-Public/usdafiles/FactSheets/tree_assistance_program-tap-fact_sheet.pdf.

To learn more about all USDA programs, visit <https://www.usda.gov/topics/disaster-resource-center>.

To learn about help for food producers related to livestock loss, forage loss, fencing, structures, water supply, please visit <https://www.farmers.gov/protection-recovery/wildfire>.

Internal Revenue Service (IRS)

Special tax law provisions may help taxpayers and businesses recover financially from the impact of a disaster, especially when the federal government declares their location to be a major disaster area. Depending on the circumstances, the IRS may grant additional time to file returns and pay taxes as well as various deductions and income exclusions for disaster-related assistance. Both individuals and businesses in a federally declared disaster area may receive a faster refund by claiming losses related to the disaster on the tax return for the previous year, usually by filing an amended return.

To learn more, visit <https://www.irs.gov/newsroom/tax-relief-presidentially-declared-disaster-areas> **or call the IRS toll-free number for general tax questions at 800-829-1040.**

United States Postal Service

Constituents who have been evacuated should check with their local county for the most up to date information or check the US Postal Service website at <https://www.usps.com>. If you are a victim of mail theft, please report the incident to your local law enforcement and the United States Postal Inspection service (USPIS) by visiting <https://www.uspis.gov>.

Veterans Affairs (VA)

If you need information regarding VA death benefits, pensions, insurance settlements, or other information related to VA, contact the federal Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) at 800-827-1000 (TDD Telecommunications Device for the Deaf 800-829-4833), or visit their Inquiry Routing and Information System (IRIS) website at <https://www.va.gov/>.

Mental Health Resources

After a disaster, it is important to tend to your emotional well-being and look out for signs of distress. During this difficult time, remember to stay active, spend time with others, take breaks, and participate in activities you enjoy.

New Mexico offers 24/7 support to anyone experiencing an emotional, mental, or substance use crisis. To reach the crisis hotline, call 988 or text “TALK” to 988.

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Para ayuda en español llame 988 y marque “2” o envíe un mensaje de texto con la palabra "HABLAR" al 988.

The Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Agency (SAMHSA) also operates the Disaster Distress Helpline to support survivors, family members, responders, and recovery workers who are affected by wildfires and other disasters. Trained counselors are available 24/7, 365 days a year. To reach the SAMHSA Disaster Distress Helpline, call or text 800-985-5990. Para ayuda en español llame 800-985-5990 y marque “2”.

To find information on helping your children cope, please visit <https://www.cdc.gov/childrenindisasters/helping-children-cope.html>.

Para más información en Español favor ir a la siguiente pagina web <https://www.cdc.gov/childrenindisasters/es/helping-children-cope.html>.

State of New Mexico Resources

The State of New Mexico has compiled various useful resources to help those impacted by fires. These resources include:

- Tips and tools to prepare for an emergency
- Evacuation center listing
- Current fire information
- Post-evacuation guide
- Agricultural and livestock resources (e.g. animal shelter locations, requests for feed for livestock)
- Housing resources
- Ways to help our fellow New Mexicans

To learn more, please visit dhsem.nm.gov/preparedness-for-residents/wildfires/ or call 800-432-2080.

Lost Document Replacement

It is possible that you may have left some of your important documentation behind when you evacuated. To learn more about replacing these documents, please refer to the information below or call my office for assistance. If you have any issues when working directly with a federal agency, please contact my office as well.

Document	Resources to Replace
Birth and Death Certificates	Visit https://www.nmhealth.org/about/erd/bvrhs/vrp/birth/ and https://www.nmhealth.org/about/erd/bvrhs/vrp/death/

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Lost Green Card	Visit https://www.uscis.gov and complete Form I-90 to complete by mail, or file online. Call 800-375-5283 to check application status
New Mexico Driver's License	Visit https://www.mvd.newmexico.gov
Medicare Cards	Visit https://www.healthcare.gov/medicare
Social Security Card	Visit https://ssa.gov or call 800-772-1213 (TTY) 888-874-7793
Military Records	Visit https://www.archives.gov/contact or call 866-272-6272
Passport	Visit https://travel.state.gov/content/travel.html or call 877-487-2778 (TTY) 888-874-7793
U.S. Tax Returns	Visit https://irs.gov/individuals/get-transcript or call 800-829-1040
New Mexico Tax Returns	Visit https://tax.newmexico.gov or call 800-285-2996

Flood Preparedness

From Ready.gov:

Preparing for a Flood

- Make a plan for your household, including your pets, so that you and your family know what to do, where to go, and what you will need to protect yourselves from flooding. Learn and practice evacuation routes, shelter plans, and flash flood response.
- Gather supplies, including non-perishable foods, cleaning supplies, and water for several days, in case you must leave immediately or if services are cut off in your area.
- Keep important documents in a waterproof container and consider creating password-protected digital copies.
- Stay alert for evacuation notices or warnings.
- Purchase or renew a flood insurance policy. Homeowner's insurance policies do not cover flooding. It typically takes up to 30 days for a policy to go into effect so the time to buy is well before a disaster. [Get flood coverage under the National Flood Insurance Program \(NFIP\)](#).

Staying Safe During a Flood

- Evacuate immediately, if told to evacuate. Never drive around barricades. Local responders use them to safely direct traffic out of flooded areas.
- Contact your healthcare provider if you are sick and need medical attention. Wait for further care instructions and shelter in place, if possible. If you are experiencing a medical emergency, call 911.
- Listen to EAS, NOAA Weather Radio or local alerting systems for current emergency information and instructions regarding flooding.
- Do not walk, swim, or drive through flood waters. Turn Around. Don't Drown!
- Stay off bridges over fast-moving water. Fast-moving water can wash bridges away without warning.

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- Stay inside your car if it is trapped in rapidly moving water. Get on the roof if water is rising inside the car.
- Get to the highest level if trapped in a building. Only get on the roof if necessary and once there signal for help. Do not climb into a closed attic to avoid getting trapped by rising floodwater.

Staying Safe After a Flood

- Pay attention to authorities for information and instructions. Return home only when authorities say it is safe.
- Avoid driving except in emergencies.
- Wear heavy work gloves, protective clothing, and boots during clean up and use appropriate face coverings or masks if cleaning mold or other debris.
- People with asthma and other lung conditions and/or immune suppression should not enter buildings with indoor water leaks or mold growth that can be seen or smelled. Children should not take part in disaster cleanup work.
- Be aware that snakes and other animals may be in your house.
- Be aware of the risk of electrocution. Do not touch electrical equipment if it is wet or if you are standing in water. Turn off the electricity to prevent electric shock if it is safe to do so.
- Avoid wading in floodwater, which can be contaminated and contain dangerous debris. Underground or downed power lines can also electrically charge the water.
- Use a generator or other gasoline-powered machinery ONLY outdoors and away from windows.

Fire Preparedness

Creating an Evacuation Plan

Making a plan is not always possible due to rapid changes in wind and other conditions, but it is important to plan ahead if you think your area could be susceptible to wildfires. Steps to take include:

- Learn your local community's evacuation plan.
- Ask friends or family members outside of your area if you can stay with them. Be mindful of current public health guidelines relating to COVID-19.
- If you have a disability, make a plan with family members and care providers.
- Check with your county emergency management office to find out what shelters are open. Follow guidance from local public health and emergency management officials on when and where to shelter.
- If you have pets, find out which shelters allow animals and up to what size. If you plan to take your pet with you, bring their medications.
- Find out which sites are sheltering larger barnyard animals if applicable.
- Pack a "go bag" (see list below).
- Place all important documents in a fireproof safe.
- Withdraw cash in case the power goes out.

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Pre-Evacuation Steps

If time allows before evacuating, please consider taking the following steps:

- Close all windows and doors. Remove all flammable window shades and curtains. Close metal shutters.
- Move flammable furniture to the middle of the room, away from doors and windows.
- Shut off gas at the meter. Turn off pilot lights and air conditioning systems.
- Gather flammable items from outside of the house (patio furniture) and bring them inside.
- Turn off all propane tanks and move appliances away from structures. Do not leave sprinklers or water running.
- Back your car into the driveway and ensure all its windows and doors are closed. Ensure your emergency kit is in the vehicle. Have a full tank of gas.

What to Bring

Pack a 3-day supply of items that are ready to go in case of an evacuation (a “go bag”). Have these items ready to go either in your car or by the door.

- Medications
- Personal hygiene items
- On-the-go disinfectant supplies
- Baby supplies, if applicable
- Pet supplies and medications, if applicable
- Cell phones with chargers and portable power bank if available
- N95 or KN95 masks (cloth and surgical masks do not protect from wildfire smoke)
- Family and emergency contact information
- Important personal documents (social security card, car registration, passport, birth certificate)

How to Stay Safe Evacuating During COVID-19

As the country continues to battle the COVID-19 pandemic, it is crucial to take into consideration the health and safety of those with whom you could shelter as well as yourself. Be sure to wash your hands (or use hand sanitizer), avoid touching high-contact surfaces or sharing food or drinks with other people. If you are not fully vaccinated, practice social distancing (6 feet from other people outside of your household) and wear a mask over your nose and mouth. Regardless of your vaccination status, follow all instructions from local officials about COVID-19 precautions in public shelters.

For other health and safety guidelines from the CDC around COVID-19 please visit <https://cv.nmhealth.org>.

Wildfire Smoke Hazards

Wildfire smoke is a mixture of air pollutants that can irritate the lungs, cause inflammation, and alter immune function. It can also increase susceptibility to respiratory infections, like COVID-19.

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People who are particularly vulnerable to wildfire smoke are:

- Children under age 18
- Adults over age 65
- Pregnant women
- People with chronic health conditions such as heart or lung disease, including asthma and diabetes

Use the Air Quality Index (AQI) to check the air quality in your area

<https://www.airnow.gov/aqi>.

If wildfire smoke affects air quality, wearing an N95 or KN95 mask can help protect you. It is important that there is a tight seal around the nose and mouth. Using a cloth mask over an N95 mask can help ensure a tighter seal.

If it is still safe to stay in your home, creating a “clean air room” can also reduce your exposure to wildfire smoke. The EPA has helpful instructions on how to do so at

<https://www.epa.gov/indoor-air-quality-iaq/create-clean-room-protect-indoor-air-quality-during-wildfire>.

For more information on protecting yourself from wildfire smoke, please visit

<https://www.cdc.gov>.

Insurance Information and Tips

Know your policy. If you don't have a copy of your policy, contact your agent or company and request it. Keep your receipts. If you are evacuated or displaced, be sure to keep copies of all restaurant, hotel, and other living expenses incurred because you cannot go home. Claims need to be filed with insurance companies, but the New Mexico Office of Superintendent of Insurance (OSI) may be able to assist citizens with questions about insurance and the claims process. For more information, please visit <https://www.osi.state.nm.us/>.

Insurance Evacuation & Claims Advice

If you are under a mandatory evacuation order, here's what you need to know about putting safety first, maintaining COVID-19 health precautions, and what to expect from your insurance coverage and claims filing process:

- First and foremost, if you are ordered to evacuate, you need to leave your residence immediately. Listen to orders from local authorities.
- COVID-19 challenges may impact evacuation shelters, lodging availability, and claims handling.
- Contact your insurance agency or company immediately to let them know where you are staying and to help you with coverage or claims questions. They can also assist you with lodging options.
- Most insurance policies cover additional living expenses if you are under a mandatory evacuation and are unable to live in your house or apartment because of a fire or other covered peril. Most policies will reimburse you the difference between your additional living expenses and your normal living expenses, but policies have set limits on the amount they will pay and may be subject to a deductible. Check with your insurance

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professional about what coverage you have and keep receipts for expenses that may be reimbursed if you file a claim.

- Take photos or videos of personal possessions, particularly antiques, artwork or custom/expensive items. If time allows, take a more complete home inventory that lists, or has pictures or videos of the contents of your home or apartment. **Only do these things if you have plenty of time – put safety FIRST.**

Returning Home After a Fire

Don't delay – Once the danger has passed, if your property has been damaged due to fire and/or smoke, don't wait – start the claim process by calling your insurance company or agent. Contact the OSI if you need the contact for your company or agent.

Document/mitigate the damage – If the damage to your home is extensive, start taking photos of the property and documenting what was lost. Protect from further damage by placing tarps on roofs or boarding up windows. **Don't begin repairs without contacting your insurance company.**

Claims settlement in the time of COVID-19 – Insurance companies have implemented safety procedures that address COVID-19 concerns to provide virtual property and inspection opportunities whenever possible in the claim settlement process. If an on-site inspection is required, adjusters are trained in proper safety precautions.

Verify public adjusters – In the aftermath of a disaster like a wildfire, public adjusters may contact you if you have suffered damage to your home. You are not required to hire a public adjuster, but if you do, make sure he or she is licensed and reputable – check references. If possible, hire a New Mexico-based adjuster. The OSI licenses adjusters and citizens can contact the OSI to verify a license. Check what the fees will be before hiring an adjuster and get information in writing.

Flood Insurance – Areas affected by wildfires are under a greater threat for flooding and mudslides due to the loss of vegetation, and the threat can last for many years as the area slowly recovers. Find information about flood insurance from the National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP) at <https://www.floodsmart.gov> or call NFIP at 800-427-4661.

If you have any questions about insurance, your policy, how things work, how to file a claim or just how to get in touch with your company or agent, contact the New Mexico Office of Superintendent of Insurance at <https://www.osi.state.nm.us>.

IRS Post-Disaster Scam Tips

Criminals and scammers often try to take advantage of generous taxpayers who want to help disaster victims. Everyone should remain vigilant as these scams often pop up after wildfires.

These disaster scams normally start with unsolicited contact. The scammer contacts their intended victim by telephone, social media, email, or in person. Scammers also use a variety of tactics to lure information out of people. Some scammers pretend they are from a charity. Bogus websites use names that are similar to legitimate charities. This is intended to trick a person into sending money or providing personal financial information.

Here are several tips to avoid becoming a victim:

- Do not give out personal financial information to anyone who solicits a contribution. This includes things like Social Security numbers or credit card and bank account numbers and passwords.

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- Scammers even claim to be working for – or on behalf of – the IRS. Scammers say they can help victims file casualty loss claims and get tax refunds.
 - Instead, you can call the IRS toll-free disaster assistance at 866-562-5227. Phone assistants will answer questions about tax relief or disaster-related tax issues.

Additional Helpful Resources

Wildfires are dangerous, unpredictable, and can change at a moment's notice. If you have a wildfire in your area, please follow the local evacuation orders and stay prepared.

- **New Mexico Fire Resources Hotline** – 800-432-2080 and <https://www.nmdhsem.org/2022-wildfires/>
- **General Information** – <https://nmfireinfo.com>
- **Map of all Wildfires** – <https://inciweb.nwcg.gov/>
- **Road Closures** – <https://www.nmroads.com>
- **Fire Restrictions Map** – <https://www.blm.gov/programs/public-safety-and-fire/fire-and-aviation/regional-info/new-mexico/fire-restrictions>
- **Smoke and Air Quality** – <https://www.env.nm.gov/air-quality/fire-smoke-links/>
- **Ready, Set, Go! NM** – <https://www.emnrd.nm.gov/sfd/fire-prevention-programs/ready-set-go-new-mexico/>

For immediate law enforcement or medical assistance, call 911. Please do not call 911 for fire information.

Summary of Local Emergency Contacts

- **Bernalillo County Emergency Management**
Thomas Walmsley, Director of Emergency Management
6840 Second St. NW
Albuquerque, NM 87107
Phone: Administration (505) 468-1306
Fax: (505) 462-9751
E-mail: emergencygmt@bernco.gov
- **Catron County Emergency Management**
Dusty Choate, Emergency Manager
PO Box 507
Reserve, NM 87830
Phone: 575-533-6498
Cell: 505-221-0031
E-mail: dusty.choate@catroncountynm.gov

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- **Chaves County Emergency Management**
Karen Sanders, Emergency Manager
P.O. Drawer 1838
Roswell, NM 88202-1838
Phone: 575-624-6740
Fax: 575-623-6750
- **Cibola County Emergency Management**
Dustin Middleton, Emergency Manager/Fire Marshal
2001 Clif Lear Ave.
Grants, NM 87020
Phone: (505) 285-2558
E-mail: dustin.middleton@co.cibola.nm.us
- **Doña Ana County Emergency Management**
Stephen Lopez, Emergency Manager
1170 North Solano, Suite O
Las Cruces, NM 88001
Phone: (575) 647-7900
- **Eddy County Emergency Management**
Jennifer Armendariz, Emergency Manager
101 W. Greene Street
Carlsbad, NM 88220
Phone: 575-499-5111
Office Phone: 575-628-5454
- **Grant County Emergency Management**
Scot Fuller, Emergency Manager
P.O. Box 898
Silver City, NM 88061
Phone: 575-956-5426
E-mail: sfuller@grantcountynm.gov
- **Hidalgo County Emergency Management**
David Whipple, Director
115 EMS Lane
Lordsburg, NM 88045
Phone: (575) 542-8272
E-mail: david.whipple@hidalgocounty.org
- **Lea County Emergency Management**
Lorenzo Velasquez, Director
1019 East Bender Boulevard
Hobbs, NM 88240
Phone: 575-605-6561
E-mail: lvelasquez@leacounty.net

- **Luna County Emergency Management**
Phillip Rodriguez, Emergency Management Coordinator
P.O. Box Drawer 1838
Roswell, NM 88202-1838
Phone: (575) 543-6569
E-mail: emergency_managment@lunacountynm.us
- **McKinley County Emergency Management**
2221 Boyd Ave.
Gallup, NM 87301
Phone: 505-772-4248
Fax: 505-722-9009
- **Otero County Emergency Management**
Matthew Clark, Emergency Services Director
1101 New York Ave.
Alamogordo, NM 88310
Phone: (575) 439-2612
E-mail: mclark@co.otero.nm.us
- **Sierra County Emergency Management**
Ryan Williams, Emergency Services Administrator
1712 N. Date, Suite D
Truth or Consequences, NM 87901
Phone: 575-894-6215
E-mail: rwilliams@sierraco.org
- **Socorro County Emergency Management**
Gail Tripp, Emergency Manager
198 Neel Ave.
Socorro, NM 87801
Phone: 575-835-2029 x1200
E-mail: grogers@co.socorro.nm.us
- **Valencia County Emergency Management**
444 Luna Avenue
P.O. Box 1119
Los Lunas, NM 87031
Phone: 505-866-2043
Phone: 505-866-2001

How My Office Can Assist

My office is here to help. If you need assistance working with a federal agency, getting replacements for federal documents, or if you simply need information about what resources are available to you, please reach out to us.

Washington DC Office 1517 Longworth House Office Building Washington, DC 20515 Phone: (202) 225- 2365	Albuquerque District Office 201 Unser Blvd. NW Unit 116 Albuquerque, NM 87121 Phone: (505) 208- 4777	Las Cruces District Office 115 W. Griggs Ave. Las Cruces, NM 88001 Phone: (575) 323- 6390	Carlsbad District Office 101 N. Halagueno St. Room #213 Carlsbad, NM 88220 For all mail correspondence, please send to the Las Cruces or DC office locations.
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